



Chief Examiner's Report

2021 Stage 2 MW exam

The 2021 Master of Wine exam year has been like no other. Having had to cancel the 2020 closed book exam, we committed to run the exam in 2021 and this meant, owing to covid-related travel restrictions, holding it in seven rather than the normal three locations. We also had to find a point in the year where the fewest restrictions were likely to be in place, without compromising planning and preparation for the 2022 exam. The executive team worked incredibly hard to make all this possible and the examiners would like to thank everyone involved in that work. The global situation has touched everybody's lives. Preparing for an exam at MW level is a challenge at the best of times and we are aware that the prevailing conditions in 2021 will have presented many additional challenges for our candidates.

A significant number of students chose not to sit the exam this year, and many were prevented from doing so on account of ongoing travel restrictions. This resulted in about 40% fewer candidates in the exam rooms compared to a 'normal' year.

This year the theory exam had a 20% pass rate (2019 = 32%) and the practical exam had an 8% pass rate (2019 = 15%). It is important to know that it is not just the number of passes that were down on historic averages this year, but the non-passing grades were also lower across the board.

Please be aware however, when considering the grades, that the grade boundaries were revised in 2020. For the practical exam this means that an "F" grade is not as disastrous, when compared to the pre-2020 grade boundaries, as it may appear. (Shown, for reference, in an appendix at the end of this report).

The standard required to pass the MW exam is fixed. There is not a quota for the pass rate, rather an absolute level (65%) which has to be met by candidates, year on year. These standards are fundamental to the rigour of the exam and are something which cannot be compromised. It is disappointing, though perhaps not surprising, to see that fewer candidates achieved the standard this year.

A candidate sitting the theory and practical parts of the exam will be exposed to up to 40 examiners in total during marking and moderation. All papers are double blind marked and all candidates are only known as numbers throughout the entire process. This rigour is at the heart of our exam and ensures that all marking is fair and consistent. For those candidates who were unsuccessful in 2021 please take heart from knowing that in future years, perhaps without the headwind of a turbulent world, success may be more readily grasped.

The theory and practical examiners have put down much good general, and question-specific feedback in what follows. We also intend to go into some further detail in the podcasts to be released in January.

Neil Tully MW

Appendix: Grade Boundary Comparison (Practical)

Percentage mark	Pre-2021 boundaries	2021 boundaries
70% +	A	A
65 – 69%	B	B
60 – 64 %	C+	C+
55 – 59%	C	C
50 – 54%	D	D
45 – 49%	D	E
40 – 44%	E	F
35 – 39%	E	F
Below 35%	E	F